

Report: Increasing Internal Yorkshire Tourism

A Strategy to Grow Yorkshire-to-Yorkshire and UK Domestic Visitor Spending

Executive Summary

Yorkshire possesses one of the strongest tourism assets in the United Kingdom: medieval cities, industrial heritage, national parks, coastline, food culture, sporting identity, and a globally recognisable regional brand. However, a significant opportunity remains underdeveloped: **internal Yorkshire tourism and tourism from other UK regions**.

While Yorkshire attracts millions of visitors, much of its tourism economy is concentrated around a small number of destinations — particularly York, the Yorkshire Dales, Whitby, Scarborough and Harrogate — while many communities struggle to capture visitor spending. The challenge is not a lack of attractions; it is a lack of **regional tourism infrastructure, marketing coordination, transport integration and product packaging**.

Tourism already represents a major economic sector:

- Yorkshire and the Humber tourism visitor spend was estimated at around **£2.4 billion in 2024** in some economic impact assessments.
- South Yorkshire alone generated approximately **£3.7 billion in visitor economy impact in 2024**, supporting more than **32,000 full-time equivalent jobs**.
- North Yorkshire's visitor economy generated approximately **£4.3 billion in 2025**, supporting almost **37,000 FTE jobs**.
- York's tourism economy alone contributed approximately **£2.01 billion in 2024**.

The opportunity is to increase the proportion of visitors who:

1. Travel **within Yorkshire** rather than leaving the county for holidays.
2. Travel from other UK regions (Midlands, London, South East, Scotland, North West).
3. Stay overnight rather than making short day trips.
4. Spread spending beyond York and the Dales.

A realistic target would be:

+10% Yorkshire domestic tourism growth over five years

Potential economic impact:

- Current Yorkshire tourism economy: approximately £6–9bn depending on methodology.
 - A 10% increase could create roughly **£600m–£900m additional annual visitor spending**.
 - Thousands of additional jobs could be supported in hospitality, transport, retail, attractions and rural economies.
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1. The Problem: Yorkshire Residents Often Holiday Elsewhere

Yorkshire has a paradox:

Yorkshire residents often travel abroad or to other UK destinations despite living beside one of Britain's richest tourism regions.

A resident of Sheffield, Leeds, Bradford or Hull may be more likely to spend a weekend in:

- London
- Edinburgh
- Manchester
- Cornwall
- Wales
- the Lake District

than exploring:

- North York Moors
- Yorkshire Wolds
- East Yorkshire coast
- South Yorkshire industrial heritage
- Yorkshire market towns

This represents a **regional export leakage**.

Money that could circulate inside Yorkshire leaves the region.

Example:

A family from Sheffield spending £800 on a Lake District weekend creates economic activity outside Yorkshire.

The same family spending £800 in Whitby, Richmond, Malham or Beverley creates:

- accommodation revenue
- restaurant spending
- attraction income
- local employment
- retail spending

2. Why Internal Yorkshire Tourism Is Weak

2.1 Yorkshire Is Marketed as Destinations, Not as a Single Experience

Yorkshire has world-class individual brands:

- York = heritage
- Whitby = coast/gothic culture
- Harrogate = spa
- Dales = walking
- Sheffield = outdoor city
- Hull = maritime culture

But Yorkshire lacks a powerful overarching narrative.

Compare:

Scotland

Marketing idea:

"One country, many experiences."

Cornwall

Marketing idea:

"Escape to the coast."

Yorkshire

Often becomes:

"Visit York"

"Visit the Dales"

"Visit Scarborough"

The county is fragmented.

2.2 Lack of Tourism Routes

Modern tourists increasingly buy **experiences**, not locations.

Examples:

Instead of:

"Visit Whitby"

create:

The Yorkshire Gothic Route

Whitby Abbey

↓

Robin Hood's Bay

↓

York medieval walls

↓

Castle Howard

↓

Harrogate Victorian architecture

Instead of:

"Visit Sheffield"

create:

The Steel & Innovation Trail

Kelham Island

↓

Peak District industrial heritage

↓

Chatsworth

↓

Matlock Bath

↓

Derwent Valley Mills

2.3 Poor Transport Integration

Yorkshire has attractions spread across a large area but limited tourism transport.

A visitor arriving in Leeds often struggles to reach:

- villages
- national parks
- coastal towns

Tourism requires:

"Leave your car at home and explore."

2.4 Yorkshire People Are Not Always Customers of Yorkshire Tourism

There is an identity gap.

Many Yorkshire residents know:

- York
- Whitby
- Dales walks

but do not perceive themselves as tourists in their own county.

Tourism marketing often targets outsiders while ignoring locals.

3. Target Markets

Market 1: Yorkshire Residents

Population:

Yorkshire and Humber:

≈5.5 million people

If only:

- 10% take one additional Yorkshire holiday annually
- spending £250 each

Economic impact:

$5.5\text{m} \times 10\% \times £250$

= **£137.5 million additional spending**

Market 2: Northern England

Target:

- Greater Manchester
- Lancashire
- North East

Population:

≈10 million+

Campaign:

"Your next adventure is one hour away."

Market 3: London and South East

The South East contains some of Britain's highest household incomes.

Target:

Weekend breaks:

- heritage
- food

- walking
- culture

Example:

London → York → Yorkshire Coast → Dales

4. Proposed Strategy

Yorkshire 365 Campaign

A county-wide tourism programme built around the idea:

"A different Yorkshire every season."

Campaign 1: The Yorkshire Passport

Create a digital tourism passport.

Visitors collect stamps.

Examples:

Heritage Passport

- York Minster
- Whitby Abbey
- Fountains Abbey
- Richmond Castle

Food Passport

- Yorkshire pudding trail
- Wensleydale cheese
- breweries
- farm shops

Adventure Passport

- Peak District
- Dales
- Moors
- Coast

Rewards:

- free attraction after 10 visits
 - hotel discounts
 - restaurant vouchers
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Campaign 2: Yorkshire Discovery Rail

Create tourism rail tickets:

Yorkshire Explorer Pass

Example:

£49 weekend ticket

Includes:

- trains
- attraction discounts
- museums

Similar models exist internationally.

Benefits:

- increases train usage
 - reduces congestion
 - encourages multi-stop tourism
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Campaign 3: Yorkshire Festival Calendar

Create a permanent annual tourism calendar.

Spring

Yorkshire Gardens Festival

Summer

Yorkshire Coast Festival

Autumn

Yorkshire Harvest Festival

Winter

Yorkshire Christmas Markets

Goal:

Remove seasonality.

Campaign 4: Promote Lesser-Known Yorkshire

Major opportunity:

East Yorkshire

Current perception:

"somewhere near Hull"

Potential:

- beaches
 - Wolds
 - historic villages
-

South Yorkshire

Potential:

"Britain's outdoor capital"

Assets:

- Peak District access
 - industrial heritage
 - music culture
-

West Yorkshire

Potential:

"Culture and creativity"

Assets:

- Leeds
 - Bradford
 - Halifax
 - Saltaire
-

Campaign 5: Yorkshire Food Tourism

Food tourism is underdeveloped.

Create:

Yorkshire Food Capital Strategy

Promote:

- Yorkshire pudding
- Wensleydale cheese
- rhubarb triangle
- seafood
- breweries
- farmers markets

Example:

"The Yorkshire Sunday Lunch Trail"

Campaign 6: Yorkshire as Britain's Adventure Region

Yorkshire should compete directly with:

- Lake District
- Snowdonia
- Scottish Highlands

Brand:

"Britain's largest adventure playground."

Assets:

- three national parks
 - coast
 - cycling
 - climbing
 - hiking
-

5. Investment Requirements

A realistic five-year programme:

Initiative	Cost
Marketing campaign	£10m
Digital passport platform	£3m
Tourism transport partnerships	£15m
Events fund	£10m
Local attraction grants	£20m
Data/analytics	£2m
Total:	

£60 million over five years

6. Funding Sources

Visitor Levy

Many UK cities are considering visitor levies to fund tourism infrastructure.

A modest:

£1 per overnight stay

could generate significant funds.

Private Sector Partnership

Hotels, attractions, restaurants and transport companies benefit directly.

Local Authority Cooperation

Replace fragmented tourism marketing with a Yorkshire Tourism Board 2.0.

7. Measuring Success

Five-year targets:

Metric	Current Problem	Target
Domestic visitors	Concentrated	+10%
Overnight stays	Too short	+20%
Rural spending	Low	+25%
Tourism jobs	Growing unevenly	+15,000
Yorkshire resident trips	Underdeveloped	+1m trips

Conclusion

Yorkshire does not suffer from a tourism shortage; it suffers from a **tourism coordination problem**.

The county already possesses:

- world heritage sites
- national parks
- coastline
- food culture
- industrial history
- strong identity

The missing element is turning Yorkshire from a collection of attractions into a unified tourism economy.

The strategic objective should be:

Make Yorkshire the first choice for a British holiday before people leave Britain.

A successful Yorkshire tourism strategy would not merely attract visitors — it would keep Yorkshire wealth circulating inside Yorkshire communities.